



foods made their way around the ballroom of the Hilton Dubai Al Habtoor City as Alastair Cook and Neetu David **(facing page, fourth pic)**, along with AB de Villiers (not in attendance) were inducted.

Captains Sophie Devine and Laura Wolvaardt, who had a final to play in less than 24 hours, were involved as volunteers for an illusionist's set.

Quick Style, a Norwegian hip-hop group that went viral for their choreography of the famous Bollywood number *Kaala Chashma*, enthralled with their moves.

Visiting the Burj Khalifa (albeit from the bottom) was also ticked off the list. A humid night in Dubai saw plenty of clouds hugging the top tiers of the tallest structure in the world. The Diary did not understand why the planners of this part of town would crowd the area around the Burj with tall buildings, taking away much of the charm of such an architectural feat.

The neighbourhood gave the Diary a crash course on the class system of taxis in Dubai. The modest-looking Careem taxis with yellow beam lights on top were not permitted to come down the runway to the popular fountain area and viewing deck. However, if you were an electric cab owner, with a Lexus or a Tesla, you could come straight through.

The Diary reconnected with an old college roommate who was building a career for herself in the city. From

cooking Indian meals in the chilly university rooms in Birmingham to sharing a lavish Egyptian breakfast plate at a quaint Arabic café on Jumeirah Beach, along with several existential conversations about joy and the lack thereof in life, we had come a long way.

The next destination was Souk Madinat Jumeirah, where the Diary sourced a set of Sheikh salt and pepper shakers — which shall take pride of place in the souvenirs cupboard at home. The afternoon was enjoyed with a drive past some of the city's most iconic landmarks, including the Burj Al Arab, the Atlantis, and the Palm Jumeirah.

A few hours later, nearly 22,000 people gathered at the Dubai International Stadium for the coronation of a new world champion. The Diary's colleague in the press box was a happy soul. It seems the washed 'good luck' shirt for the White Ferns, which was draped over a seat, did the trick after all.

The team sang Māori songs and danced late into the night, barefoot on the pitch where they made history. Suzie Bates, Sophie Devine, Lea Tahuhu, and their young teammates turned around a challenging year with the one win that mattered the most.

Perhaps that's the best souvenir we could take back home after three testing yet satisfying weeks of World Cup cricket in the desert.

